



If you shoot a lot consider a hard drive based camcorder, the extra storage space is worth the premium



Flash based camcorders are becoming cheaper thanks to the greatly diminished price of flash memory

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Contact sheet Camcorder comparison test

Brand	Contact	Phone	Email	Web site
Canon	Canon India Pvt Ltd	1800-180-33-66	info@canon.co.in	www.canon.co.in
Samsung	Samsung India Electronics Pvt Ltd	+91-11-4151 1234	zion.kim@samsung.com	www.samsung.com/in
Sony	Sony India Pvt Ltd	1800-11-11-88	sonyindia.care@ap.sony.com	www.sony.co.in

lier, and so the HG10 had big boots to fill. Unfortunately, it didn't live up to our expectations and while outdoor shooting was good, indoor shooting was considerably inferior to the other Canon and Sony HD models. Still image quality was also not that good. The OIS system works reasonably well, although it's not as effective as those on the other HF camcorders. In fact, it's nearly on a par with the Sony HDR-CX100, which didn't impress us in terms of the resulting image stability.

Priced at Rs. 89,995, the HG10 is expensive and is outperformed by the other HD camcorders in this shootout. We can't recommend it, not at that MRP and perhaps not even at half the price.

SAMSUNG SMX-F30BP Value for the masses

Samsung's SMX-F30BP is touted as a flash-based camcorder with 16 GB of memory. The device itself is a bright silver colour and looks lively. The build quality of the finish is also good and the camcorder looks rounded without any sharp edges. The LCD is not as good as we'd expect from Samsung, but it's better than the unit of the DX205. Sadly there's no variable zoom (one feature we really loved on the other units) and the camcorder tends to zoom too quickly — this is bad. Although this camcorder isn't exactly compact, the record button is too close to your hand, which is uncomfortable. Interestingly, the palm grip swivels to a vertical alignment. Since the default grip works best, we don't know what Samsung was thinking — with the grip vertically aligned it's actually a lot more uncomfortable.

The mode button to select between record, capture and play is well located and easy to use. The absence of an auto-focus means that images are a basic function.

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Samsung SMX-F30BP

Video quality indoors was poor; in fact there was considerable loss of detail with the noise that crept into nearly the entire video. Outdoor shooting was much better, although only until you start to use the zoom. Once the zoom is used, the digital image stabilisation (DIS hereon) kicks in and quite frankly does not do much. We prefer OIS much better, DIS does not compensate for regular body movements and the resulting jitter is very evident from the videos. Maybe we're nitpicking, because we tested the excellent HD camcorders first, but saying its performance could have been better is a gross understatement.

We weren't impressed until the point we saw its price. At Rs. 16,900, the SMX-F30BP is the dream come true for someone looking at their first foray into the world of camcorders. Sure it's far from the best around, but for the price, it's good value for money.

SAMSUNG VP-DX205 For the disk lover

This was the only MiniDVD camcorder we received. This was different from the disk recorders that we received last year. They stored only video on the disk and images had to be stored on an added memory card. This present camcorder can even store videos on an SD card — a plus for flexibility. It's a very simple looking camcorder that's nevertheless built quite well. Samsung uses a smooth metallic finish coupled with a dull textured finish that makes for quite a welcome contrast. The colours are black with gun-grey and quite frankly attractive.

The lens flap has a nice positive slide open and close. The disk flap button is also well located so that you can operate it with your thumb. Once again the lack of a variable speed zoom is annoying, once you have become accustomed to this feature you really cannot do without it. The zoom is quite fast as a result, and at the long end of the zoom, the lens takes some time to focus on subjects. The photo button is easy to use and clicks easily — a pleasure after Canon's hard buttons. There is no autofocus for still images.

In terms of performance, the VP-DX205 performed slightly worse compared to its sibling and we were quite frankly surprised. It doesn't help that there is some lag associated with writing to mini-DVD disks. The DIS system works a lot better than the system on the VP-DX205. Still images are also not fun and are not as clear as we would expect. Priced at Rs. 18,990, the VP-DX205 is obviously for the user on a budget who prefers the good old optical disk.



Samsung VP-DX205

CANON FS10 Classy looking, mediocre performer

The FS10 is a sleek looking camcorder, finished in glossy silver that is immediately eye-catching. It's built well and feels solid in-hand. Quality of materials used is top class. Although this camcorder isn't the most compact we've seen, it definitely scores points for ergonomic placement of the record button. You never have to really bend your thumb or align your grip to use this camcorder — a serious plus in our books. The photo button is also easy to use and well placed. Available with 8 GB of flash with additional memory expansion option available, the FS10 should not run out of memory considering at its highest quality it uses only around nine mbps.

The viewfinder is pretty good, and although it's not as legible as the other two Canon HD camcorders in bright sunlight, it's clear, crisp and offers good brightness levels for indoor shooting. Image quality both indoors and outdoors was not too good, although in dim lighting the lack of quality becomes even more apparent. One point we liked was that the DIS system was



slightly better than the Samsung camcorders, although it was nowhere near the quality of the OIS based devices. Audio quality was slightly below par, although to be honest you'll notice the lack of video clarity first.

Priced at Rs 30,995, the Canon FS10 is a little expensive when one considers the excellent pricing on the Sony camcorders. How can we recommend even a decent non-HD camcorder when an HD camcorder is available for a meagre Rs. 5,000 — 6,000 more? ■

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